



From Skills to Action: Applying Green Practices in SMEs

🕒 15 min · Supporting learning resource (LSM)

Module 2 · From Awareness to Action-Skills for Sustainable Business

Subunit 2.5 – From Skills to Action: Applying Green Practices in SMEs

→ Introduction

Sustainability in SMEs does not begin with complex strategies or large investments. It begins with understanding, continues with small actions, and develops through consistent application.

Throughout Module 2, learners explored green skills, organisational roles, everyday practices, and behavioural factors. Each of these elements contributes to sustainability in a different way. However, real impact is achieved only when they are combined and applied in practice.

This unit focuses on this transition—from knowing to doing. It supports learners in identifying realistic opportunities for action and encourages them to take the first steps towards more sustainable practices in their organisations.

Key concepts explained

From green skills to practical application

Green skills include awareness, critical thinking, and the ability to identify improvements. However, these skills are meaningful only when applied in real situations.

👉 Example:

An employee understands that excessive energy use increases costs and environmental impact. Instead of leaving equipment running, they begin switching it off when not needed. This simple action reflects the application of knowledge in practice.

This demonstrates that sustainability starts with small, conscious decisions.

Linking roles, behaviour and action

Sustainability in SMEs depends on how roles and behaviour interact.

Managers may define sustainability goals, but employees implement them through daily actions. At the same time, behaviour—such as habits and routines—can either support or hinder implementation.

👉 Example:

A manager introduces a policy to reduce printing. However, employees continue printing documents out of habit.

In this case, the role is defined, but behaviour prevents effective implementation.

This shows that successful action requires alignment between:

- roles
- behaviour
- organisational support

Prioritising actions: What should come first?

Not all sustainability actions have the same value or feasibility. SMEs need to prioritise actions to ensure effective implementation.

Two key criteria can be used:

Impact

How much environmental or operational benefit does the action provide?

Feasibility

How easy is it to implement, considering time, cost, and resources?

👉 **Example:**

Replacing all equipment may have high impact but low feasibility.

Switching off unused devices has moderate impact but high feasibility.

Starting with feasible actions helps build momentum and confidence.

From individual practices to organisational change

Sustainability often begins with individual actions, but its impact increases when these actions are shared and adopted by others.

👉 **Example:**

In a small office, one employee starts using digital documents instead of printing. Gradually, colleagues adopt the same practice, and the organisation reduces paper use significantly.

This illustrates how individual behaviour can lead to collective change.

Reflection prompts

- What are the most realistic sustainability actions in your organisation?
- Which practices could be improved immediately?
- What barriers might affect implementation?
- What is one action you can start today?

Link to next unit

This unit concludes Module 2 by focusing on practical application.

The next module will explore how these practices can be integrated into organisational strategies, governance structures, and long-term planning.

Identifying realistic opportunities for action

For SMEs, the key to sustainability is not complexity, but practicality.

Organisations should focus on identifying actions that are:

- easy to implement
- low-cost
- relevant to daily operations

Typical opportunities include:

- reducing unnecessary energy consumption
- improving resource efficiency
- simplifying processes
- raising awareness among employees

👉 **Example:**

A small retail business identifies that lighting is left on after closing hours. By introducing a simple closing checklist, energy use is reduced without any financial investment.

Key takeaways

Sustainability is achieved through the combination of skills, roles, practices, and behaviour.

Small, realistic actions can lead to significant results over time.

Behavioural change is essential for implementing sustainability decisions.

Starting small and building gradually is the most effective approach for SMEs.

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